



CUE THE SOUND

From sidelined accessories to an engorging, full-fledged category, headphones have come a long way, and the innovation is nowhere close to having peaked

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

Headphones and earphones have become an integral part of many people's daily lives.

We, for one, couldn't imagine a day without our trusty pair of headphones, be it our noise cancelling cans, our gaming headsets, or our compact and comfortable truly wireless in-ears. However, the overbearing reliance on headphones for the masses wasn't as much of a thing in the past as it has transpired to become now. Rewind back a couple of decades and most consumers, apart from avid audiophiles, will remember headphones or earphones being an afterthought, of sorts. Something you'd perchance receive packaged with your shiny new phone, or something you'd buy, sometimes for as cheap as possible, just to take calls and listen to a song or two. Now, they've become much more. They're your partners in crime when you want to transport yourself to your musical haven, eliminate the noise around you, take calls, interact with your voice assistant, and more. Companies are increasingly making strides in headphone innovation to make them into appealing commodities, brimming with features that one can't help but desire. The future, in our opinion, will continue to see rapid innovation in this field. First, let's take a look back at the humble

beginnings of audio gadgets and the years of innovation that have made them into the must-have gadgets they've become today.

A PEEK INTO THE PAST

Headphones have been adorning our heads for almost a century now, gradually evolving from a niche product to a mass market category generating over \$1 billion in revenue. The first pair of headphones ever worn were produced way back in 1881. It was used by a telephone operator and a single earpiece rested on the operator's shoulder, weighing over 10 pounds! The device was invented by Ezra Gilliland, who also invented the telephone switchboard and the magneto bell. In 1895, the idea of headphones for commercial

or personal use started gaining some momentum. The headphones produced for commercial use looked like stethoscopes and were exorbitantly priced. This setup was used by people around London to tune into live performances, and even Sunday church services.

French engineer, Ernest Mercadier, patented a set of in-ear headphones in 1891. He was granted US Patent No. 454,138 for "improvements in telephone-receivers... which shall be light enough to be carried while in use on the head of the operator." Basically, Mercadier produced miniature receivers that weighed less than 1 and $\frac{3}{4}$ ounces and were meant to be inserted into the ear, thus being much more compact and lightweight than the headsets that came before. His design is also remarkably similar to the contemporary in-ear headphones, down to the usage of a rubber cover, or now known as silicone eartips, to "lessen the friction against the orifice of the ear... effectually close the ear to external sounds." Zoom forward to 1910, when Nathaniel Baldwin created something akin to the modern headphone, hand-made in his very own kitchen! While private investors scoffed at this device at the time, the US Navy embraced it and bought dozens of devices for their radio operators, making



Headphones for commercial use in 1895

Image Credit: Electrophone advertisement (British Telephone Systems)